

HILTON, BECERRA PULLING AHEAD OF STEYER

Race for governor remains unsettled, but billionaire Democrat faces elimination.

By NICOLE NIXON AND SEEMA MEHTA

As election officials continued tallying ballots Wednesday, Republican Steve Hilton and Democrat Xavier Becerra continued to lead in the unsettled race to replace termed-out Gov. Gavin Newsom, with billionaire Democrat Tom Steyer hoping for a surge in late-arriving votes to push him into one of the top two spots to advance to the November general election.

Hilton, a British immigrant and former Fox News commentator, told reporters outside the state Capitol in Sacramento on Wednesday morning that he was “very encouraged” by the latest results, though he stopped short of declaring victory.

“It does look as if change is coming to California, and that is good news for everyone, every small business, every working family, everyone who wants to see our state set back on track,” he said.

Becerra and Steyer did not hold public events as of Wednesday afternoon.

Election data analyst Paul Mitchell said it would be nearly mathematically impossible for Steyer to close the gap.

“As we start to get more data, the runway is going to get shorter and shorter,” he said.

He said Steyer, to finish in the top two in the primary, would have to get about 30% of the remaining uncounted votes while Becerra would need to be limited to 15%. The self-funded billionaire has “a very high hill to overcome, and the challenge gets steeper and steeper as we get more data from the counties,” Mitchell said.

Once mired near the bottom of a crowded pack of Democrats in opinion polls, Becerra, a former Biden administration Cabinet member, rocketed ahead of his rival candidates after former Rep. Eric Swalwell dropped out of the race in April amid allegations of sexual assault and misconduct. The scandal triggered an upswing of voter interest in California’s once sluggish governor’s race and in Becerra, who seized the moment.

[See **Governor**, A7]



Photographs by KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

WORKERS count ballots Wednesday at the processing center in City of Industry. Mail ballots are still arriving, and hundreds of thousands may be left to be tallied.

Uncounted ballots are expected to swing blue

Latest results may boost progressives, experts say

By GRACE TOOHEY

With many races still very tight and millions of ballots yet to be counted, political experts said Democrats are likely to hold — or even gain — the edge as results of the primary election come into focus.

Republicans appear to have over-performed in early vote counts, but for a variety of reasons, experts believe the ballots will lean more Democratic as the latest vote-by-mail ballots are counted. This could benefit progressives in close races, but by how much remains an open question.

“Don’t count [Councilmember] Nithya Raman out yet,” said Zev Yaroslavsky, director of the Los Angeles Initiative at UCLA Luskin, who closely tracks

local elections.

Raman is currently in third place behind Mayor Karen Bass, who has secured a spot in the runoff, and reality TV personality Spencer Pratt. Raman would have to make up significant ground to reach Pratt and receive a sizable portion of remaining votes.

“Pratt has an edge ... but it’s not free from doubt at this point,” Yaroslavsky said.

Rob Stutzman, a longtime GOP strategist, agrees the remaining vote count will skew more strongly for Democrats, but he’s “not so sure it’s going to change where we’re at.”

“I don’t think [See **Votes**, A6]

How Bass has weathered this brutal campaign

A broad coalition of supporters buoyed the mayor into the runoff election in November.

By DAVID ZAHNISER AND NOAH GOLDBERG

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass took office four years ago with a reputation as a coalition builder — someone capable of bringing competing factions together to achieve a common goal.

On Wednesday, that goal became Bass’ reelection this fall. In a bruising primary campaign, a broad coalition of supporters assembled by the mayor helped her secure a spot in the Nov. 3 runoff, even as her top two rivals — reality TV personality Spencer Pratt and City Councilmember Nithya Ra-

man — battled for the second spot on the ballot.

The mayor’s coalition featured organized labor, including the powerful police officers’ union; business leaders, working closely with Airbnb; the Los Angeles County Democratic Party, including key elected officials; and immigrant rights groups who applauded Bass for her condemnation of federal ICE raids.

“You don’t often get business and labor on the same side. You don’t often get police and progressives on the same side,” said political strategist Kerman Maddox, a longtime friend of Bass, not long after the Associated Press declared Tuesday that Bass would make the runoff. “She did it tonight, and we’re going to do it again in the runoff.”

It wasn’t yet clear Wednesday which opponent [See **Bass**, A6]

Using voting map to their benefit

Democrats advance in most congressional races, but one contest is cause for concern.

By KEVIN RECTOR

Buoyed by a new congressional map favoring their party, California Democrats eyed Tuesday’s primary elections as a critical first step toward flipping a handful of House seats and taking back power in Washington.

As of Wednesday, the results were a mixed bag — with Democratic candidates advancing to November’s general election as expected in several districts that were redrawn in their favor as a result of last year’s Proposition 50 ballot measure, but early results in another race considered critical to

their majority aspirations causing unease.

One of the most closely watched races was in the redrawn 22nd Congressional District in the Central Valley, where incumbent Rep. David Valadao (R-Hanford) is facing challenges from moderate Assemblymember Jasmeet Bains (D-Delano) and progressive college professor Randy Villegas.

Valadao easily advanced to the November general election, according to the Associated Press, while Villegas and Bains were still fighting for a second-place finish as of Wednesday.

Another closely watched race was in the redrawn 48th Congressional District in San Diego and Riverside counties, where Rep. Darrell Issa (R-Bonsall) decided to retire rather than run for reelection, and where Republican San Diego County Sur- [See **Congressional**, A7]

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L.A. voters split on incumbents

As the city attorney succumbs to challengers, the controller seems poised for victory. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Sales tax measure trails

Early returns had a majority of voters opposing a half-cent increase for healthcare. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Possible runoff for sheriff

L.A. County Sheriff Robert Luna has an early edge over predecessor Alex Villanueva. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

LAUSD members take lead

Three on school board surge ahead after facing limited organized opposition. **CALIFORNIA, B3**

Heat wave illnesses can now be tracked

New L.A. County tool offers weather-linked data to the public on a ‘near real time’ basis.

By BLANCA BEGERT

For the first time, Los Angeles County residents can see how many people are ending up in emergency rooms, their bodies pushed past the limit, during heat waves.

The county Department of Public Health says its new Heat-Related Illness and Mortality Dashboard will provide heat illness counts in “near real time,” which means weekly. That might seem like a lag, but until now the data were only provided upon request and in ad hoc reports.

Heat is the leading cause of weather-related death in the United States and heat waves are only getting more

frequent and intense as the climate changes.

Public health experts called the tracker a meaningful step toward assessing how well county programs are addressing heat risks.

“It’s showing the county’s commitment to reducing the burden of heat on people’s health,” said David Eisenman, director of UCLA’s Center for Public Health and Disasters. “As the county puts more resources into that, this is a metric that allows the public to judge the effectiveness of the work.”

“There’s a handful of other places that also do this, but they’re all relatively new,” said Bharat Venkat, director of the UCLA Heat Lab, noting as examples Imperial and Riverside counties in California, Harris County in Texas and Maricopa County in Arizona. “It is very much welcome.”

The tracker takes heat ill- [See **Heat**, A11]

Trump’s pick loses in Iowa

Rare defeat of a gubernatorial hopeful with presidential backing exposes GOP voter divisions. **NATION, A5**

Pelley is fired at ‘60 Minutes’

A correspondent who accused boss of “murdering” the show loses his job a day after the criticism. **BUSINESS, A9**

A ‘summer shed’ on waterfront

Long Beach tests idea for Hollywood Bowl-style amphitheater with temporary venue. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Clouds, then sun. L.A. Basin: 81/61. **B6**

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U.S.’ latest Mexican targets

Washington is investigating two governors suspected of having connections to organized crime

By STEVE FISHER AND KATE LINTHICUM



MARCO UGARTE Associated Press

ALFONSO DURAZO, left, governor of Sonora, still travels to the U.S. via a parole program, sources say.

MEXICO CITY — The U.S. is investigating two prominent Mexican governors, multiple sources said, as the Trump administration expands its campaign against high-level Mexican officials suspected of ties to organized crime.

The move against sitting government officials threatens to undermine Mexico’s ruling party — which came to power on a promise to combat corruption — and further strain the already tense relationship between the two countries.

For years, the U.S. refrained from investigating sitting politicians in its fight against drug trafficking, preferring to target cartel leaders. But as many of Mexico’s most notorious drug traffickers have been killed, arrested or have turned themselves in, Washington has shifted its attention to prosecuting elected leaders and law enforcement agents suspected of involvement in organized crime.

[See **Mexico**, A4]